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Us Versus Them: Ethnic Inequality, Diversionary Nationalism, and International Conflict

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Abstract: How does political inequality among ethnic groups motivate governments to engage in international conflicts? Previous research suggests that ethnic political inequality leads to internal instability and civil conflict. Nevertheless, the impact of such political inequality on international conflicts is less clear. This study addresses this gap by proposing that states who exclude large ethnic populations from the political system often (1) generate deep grievances along ethnic lines and (2) make state leaders depend more on a narrower ethnic coalition for political survival. Structural political inequality limits the state's ability to adequately address domestic turmoil via co-optation and repression, since these solutions either upset the ethnic groups in power or are too costly to implement. These constraints prompt leaders of ethnically exclusive states to turn to diversionary conflict, especially against international rivals, to increase their co-ethnics' cohesion and rally for their support. Statistical models of over 2800 dyads of states between 1946 and 2014 (totaling over 112,000 dyad-years) support this argument. In addition, the findings show that, when states face both severe ethnic inequality and domestic turmoil, they are especially belligerent against not only rivals but particularly rivals who marginalize the home state's ethnic groups in power.

Introduction

On September 25th, 1963, King Hassan II of Morocco ordered his Royal Moroccan Army to cross into Algeria's territory, officially igniting the "Sand War". What began as minor skirmishes over poorly demarcated colonial frontiers turned into four weeks of intense fighting, followed by months of hostilities. The war drew direct military intervention from Cuba and Egypt as well as notable diplomatic involvement from the United States and the Arab League. Although the war ended in early 1964, it marked the beginning of an entrenched rivalry that threatens regional stability for decades.

Territorial ambiguity alone, however, does not explain the timing of this conflict. Morocco in the early 1960s was politically fragile. Just a few years earlier (1958-1959), the Rif region erupted in a violent uprising that required direct intervention by Hassan, then crown prince and army chief of staff, resulting in thousands of casualties. Beneath this Rif Revolt lay a deeper structural feature of Moroccan politics: ethnic political inequality. Despite constituting roughly 40% of the population,[1] ethnic Berbers were excluded from executive power, received limited economic support, and faced cultural discrimination from the Arab-dominated government. At the same time, segments of the Arab population embraced an aggressive nationalist agenda, putting pressure on the monarchy to make territorial claims against its neighbors to establish a "Greater Morocco" (S. G. Miller 2013).

Given the dual problem of grievances from marginalized Berbers and pressures from co-ethnic Arab nationalists, external conflict offered a political solution: it diverted attention from internal unrest and strengthened cohesion among the regime's core ethnic constituency. The Sand War thus illustrates a broader possibility: ethnic political inequality may not only fuel civil conflict but also shape international conflict.

While the literature in intrastate conflict and civil war has found the inequality-conflict nexus to be a robust relationship (Bartusevičius 2014; Cederman et al. 2013, 2011; Hillesund et al. 2018; Buhaug et al. 2014), the link between ethnic inequality and international conflict remains underexplored. Research on diversionary conflict has hinted that internal ethnic conflict and economic inequality are important factors that push leaders to start interstate disputes. Despite this, ethnic political inequality has not been directly examined. Meanwhile, the irredentist literature recognizes ethnic dominance as a driver of aggressive and nationalist foreign policies, yet does not specify under which circumstances political inequality would motivate leaders to start international conflicts (Goemans and Schultz 2017; Saideman and Ayres 2008).

This study addresses this gap and connects both sets of literature by giving direct attention to how unequal access to state resources and power affects the way states wage international conflicts. Such an endeavor is important for at least two reasons. First, a focus on ethnic political inequality sheds light on how ethnic identities influence and are leveraged by leaders' international

[1] According to the Ethnic Power Relations dataset (Vogt et al. 2015).

actions. Many quantitative analyses and case studies indicate that leaders may instigate external conflicts to distract the public from domestic issues and foster national unity through appeals to nationalism (Oakes 2012; Butcher 2021; Fordham 1998; Mitchell and Prins 2004; Lee et al. 2022). Such a rally-round-the-flag mechanism means that international conflicts, especially for diversionary purposes, are fundamentally linked to in-group/out-group feelings and identity politics, of which ethnic inequality is a significant contributing factor (Haynes 2016).

Second, a clearer understanding of (unequal) ethnic power relations and states' international behavior improves our practical understanding of world politics. Very few countries in the modern world are close to being ethnically homogeneous. Even in relatively less diverse countries such as Saudi Arabia and Germany, ethnic minorities still constitute a notable portion of the population (Alesina et al. 2003). Given the recent global rise in nationalist foreign policies as well as growing pressure from excluded groups for more representation or even self-determination (Peleg 2007; Wimmer 2012), it is both interesting and important to examine how ethnic power relations impact leaders' turn to aggressive rhetoric and military actions that reinforce the nationalist narrative.

Borrowing from the literatures on civil war, irredentism, and diversionary conflict, this study argues that ethnic political inequality heightens ethnic identity salience, encouraging exclusionary nationalism among groups in power while generating grievances among excluded groups. These dynamics create a structural condition in which leaders must simultaneously appease their narrow ethnic support base and manage threats from marginalized populations.

Domestic security crises (particularly mass unrest) intensify these tensions and heighten threats to the leader and state survival. Facing this double threat, leaders may respond by repression, co-optation, and/or diversion (Oakes 2012, 2006; Morgan and Palmer 2000; Davies 2016, 2002). Where excluded groups constitute large portions of the population, structural inequality increases leaders' dependence on dominant co-ethnics while constraining the feasibility or effectiveness of repression and accommodation. Under these conditions, diversionary conflict becomes more attractive: initiating interstate disputes can strengthen cohesion among core ethnic supporters and rally their backing, especially when rivals marginalize the state's ethnic kin.

Empirical findings support this argument. States that exclude large ethnic populations from executive power are more likely to initiate international disputes during periods of domestic mass unrest. These states are also more likely to target international rivals, particularly those that marginalize the home state's ethnic kin, enabling leaders to frame conflict in ethnic nationalist terms and mobilize co-ethnic support.

Consistent with prior research, the results suggest that ethnic nationalism – reinforced through external conflict – can serve as a viable option for leaders' political survival. More broadly, they demonstrate how ethnic political inequality generates conditions that threaten stability both domestically and internationally. Amid the contemporary surge in nationalist and

populist politics, these findings help us explain and anticipate how identity-based inequalities can shape a state's conflict behavior and how internal dynamics can produce instability across borders.

Inequality, Identity Politics and Conflict: A Literature Review

Overall, the role of political inequality among ethnic groups has been a focal point of civil conflict research, with influential studies finding a robust link between ethnic political inequality and civil war. However, even though many studies have shown ethnic inequality to be an important factor in the outbreak of interstate disputes and irredentist conflicts, the imbalance in political access among ethnic groups has mainly been treated as a background moderating variable.

Key Concepts

Before discussing past research as well as theoretical mechanisms linking ethnic inequality to diversionary conflict, a discussion of key concepts is in order. This study follows the Weberian tradition and defines *ethnicity and ethnic identity* as people's subjective belief in their common descent due to similarities in their phenotypic traits and/or customs, regardless of whether such commonalities actually exist (Hutchinson and Smith 1996, 35). Such commonalities often revolve around common ancestry and descent-based attributes (Horowitz 1985; Fearon and Laitin 2000).

Intertwined but distinct from ethnicity, *nationalism* is a sentiment that unifies individuals who share a collective belief in *a larger political community* (the nation) as well as *the state* that represents that community (Marx 2003, 5; Tudor and Slater 2021). In other words, while national and ethnic identity both serve as a unifying belief that binds individuals into a larger collective, nationalism as a belief is distinct in that it (1) may or may not necessarily include descent-based attributes and (2) specifically entails individuals' attachment and obligation to *the state* (Tudor and Slater 2021; Solt 2011).

Next, *ethnic political inequality* is defined as the disproportionate access to and control of state power and resources among ethnic groups (Chandra and Wilkinson 2008, 537). While Chandra and Wilkinson include ethnic groups' specific access to the military, the police, education, and the economy as part of their definition, I opt for only the core logic of their conceptualization as it encompasses ethnic groups' access and control of the broader political system – and thus is connected to how ethnic groups perceive themselves and their political realities.

This study's concept of ethnic political inequality taps into one specific aspect of the broader concept of horizontal inequality (or between-group inequality), defined as "inequalities in economic, social or political dimensions or cultural status between culturally defined groups" (Stewart 2008). The focus of this study is narrower in two ways. For one, this research explicitly focuses on ethnicity as the central type of identity rather than other types of "culturally defined groups." Additionally, the paper also centers its attention on political inequality rather than other dimensions of horizontal inequality.

In this paper, I operationalize ethnic political inequality as the size of ethnic groups excluded from access to state power and resources (Cederman et al. 2011, 2013). By incorporating both political exclusion and size of ethnic groups, this operationalization captures the presence and severity of ethnic exclusion in a political system. Specifically, if smaller ethnic groups gain access to a state's political resources while large ethnic groups are excluded (i.e., disproportionate political access), it is safe to argue that the country's system as a whole has an imbalance or inequality in how political resources (and likely other types of resources) are distributed across ethnic lines.

Political Inequality, Identity, and Conflict Within States

Following the constructivist approach, scholars have established that ethnic and national identities are fluid, non-permanent, and can overlap with each other – depending on the level of shared experiences and history among groups and individuals (Hale 2004; Brubaker 2006; Mylonas and Tudor 2021).

An important implication that follows is that ethnic and national identities can be shaped by political actors and social conditions. Most notably, the state can use policies such as assimilation, accommodation, or exclusion to influence people's national and ethnic attachments (Singh and vom Hau 2016). State policies directly aimed at nation-building can diffuse ethnic tensions and promote a unifying national identity (Miguel 2004). Other than providing public goods such as education and employment, states can even wage wars to encourage individuals to identify with the nation-state (Robinson 2014; Sambanis et al. 2015).

In contrast, states can also choose to deal with their ethnically diverse population by creating and/or maintaining systems with high levels of horizontal (political) inequality, prioritizing one or a few groups while excluding the others. Such exclusive systems can strengthen intra-group belonging and inter-group cleavages. Given that individuals often compare between the status of their group and that of other groups (Brewer 1979; Bettencourt et al. 2001), political, economic, and social inequalities among ethnic groups can lead to a perception of injustice, prompting group members to attribute such injustice to other groups or the government (Buhaug et al. 2014; Cederman et al. 2013). This pattern, combined with the fluidity of identities, enables ethnic entrepreneurs to craft narratives that increase group cohesion and facilitate violent mobilization against the state (Hillesund et al. 2018; Cederman et al. 2013).

Political Inequality, Identity, and Conflict Between States

There is surprisingly little research on ethnic political inequality's impact on international conflict. Some research has pointed out that ethnic discrimination – a form of political inequality – leads to more interstate disputes (Caprioli and Trumbore 2003, 2006), arguing that discriminative states are more likely to fight because they have less respect for peaceful norms of politics and often view violence as an acceptable dispute resolution. However, their argument may not necessarily generalize to a broader set of states that exclude (but not necessarily discriminate

against) ethnic groups. In addition, this logic assumes that the state simply makes foreign policy from its internal values, overlooking the role of identity politics and the agency of ethnic groups (even the marginalized) in shaping a government's international behavior.

Political inequality among ethnic groups also appears in studies on ethnic nationalism and irredentism. Collectively, these studies show that nationalism is a crucial fuel for conflict between nation-states, especially to reunite with their co-nationals who are separated by territorial borders and ruled by ethnic others (Wimmer 2012; Saideman and Ayres 2008; Shelef 2016). Notably, this phenomenon, known as irredentism, is most likely in the presence of ethnic political inequality: when a state is ethnically homogeneous or dominated by an ethnic majority, political elites are incentivized to pursue policies fueled by ethnic or exclusive nationalism, including aggressive foreign policy, to appease the dominant ethnic group(s) (Saideman and Ayres 2008; Goemans and Schultz 2017).

However, even though political hierarchy among ethnic groups is an essential condition that allows political elites to pursue nationalist policies for their own gains, ethnic inequality is treated as a moderating variable and remains under-examined. Furthermore, while political exclusion of ethnic groups may create important structural conditions, leaders cannot engage in nationalist wars at all times. Studies of irredentism have not deeply examined conditions or events that make politicians feel the need to engage in such risky conflicts in one year and not in another.

The literature of diversionary conflict offers insights into events and conditions that make aggressive foreign policies more attractive to political elites. These conditions can include domestic strife (Gelpi 1997; Pickering and Kisangani 2005, 2010; Davies 2002), economic struggles (Mitchell and Prins 2004; Oneal and Tir 2006), or low public approval (Derouen 2000; Fordham 2002). Such internal problems can threaten the elites' hold on power, motivating them to use militarized actions to (1) divert the public's attention from internal problems and (2) rally for political support from domestic audiences (Levy and Vakili 1992, 119).

The effect of internal problems is magnified when political elites operate in structural conditions that make diversionary conflict even more feasible or beneficial for leaders – such as low state capacity (Oakes 2012, 2006). Nevertheless, despite being both an important internal problem and structural condition, ethnic political inequality has not received a dedicated focus from the literature on diversionary conflict.

Political Inequality and Gaps in the Theoretical Narrative

In summary, despite evidence suggesting the central role of ethnic political inequality in many political processes, few direct investigations have been made on how ethnic political inequality influences international conflict behavior. This gap is important to address. Given its impact on a state's internal politics, ethnic inequality can also substantially shape state leaders' international behavior. The literature on nationalist-irredentist conflict discusses ethnic dominance's importance in incentivizing leaders to utilize aggressive and nationalist foreign

policies yet does not specify the circumstances that can trigger leaders to engage in such aggression. Similarly, while the literature of diversionary conflict provides insights into conditions that fuel elites' decisions to engage in interstate conflicts, it leaves the exploration of ethnic political inequality unattended. This study addresses this gap by bringing together three different bodies of research in civil conflict, nationalism, and diversionary conflict to directly investigate whether and how ethnic political inequality makes states turn more internationally aggressive.

Ethnic Inequality, Nationalism, and Diversionary Conflict: A Theoretical Argument

Overall, this study argues that ethnic (political) inequality – particularly when the marginalized ethnic groups are large – makes ethnic identity politically salient and heightens ethnic tensions. Between-group inequality narrows the state's selectorate to its own ethnic base, while making large marginalized populations a latent threat. Ethnic political inequality also encourages the development of ethnic/exclusionary nationalism among *ethnic groups in power (EGIPs)* while generating grievances among *ethnic groups excluded from power (EGEs)*. These dynamics create a structural condition where state leaders survive by appealing to the support of their narrow ethnic coalition and maintaining EGIPs' cohesion while deterring potential threats from marginalized groups.

Domestic security crises (particularly mass unrest) can intensify these tensions and threaten the leader's and even state's survival. Facing the double threat of domestic turmoil and ethnic inequality, states can respond by choosing one or several major policy directions: repression, co-optation/accommodation, and diversion (Oakes 2012, 2006; Morgan and Palmer 2000; Davies 2016, 2002). If dissent originates from large and excluded groups (EGEs), repression is costly, especially at a large scale and in a sustained manner, while adequate cooptation (if at all possible) is politically risky as it may severely undermine the ruler's legitimacy among her own co-ethnic base. If dissent originates from segments of EGIPs, substantial accommodation is materially costly and signals weakness to not only other segments of the ethnic base but also the marginalized ethnic groups, prompting them to mobilize and make demands of their own. Repression against the co-ethnic opposition groups is even harder as it risks further fragmenting its own ethnic base and endangering the leader's position.

Given the difficulty of implementing repression and co-optation in a comprehensive and sustained manner, diversionary conflict becomes an enticing option. *Diversion does not directly resolve grievances among excluded groups*. Rather, it helps leaders to maintain their positions by shifting domestic attention toward external threats, thereby consolidating support and cohesion within their co-ethnic base through nationalist appeals while signaling strength to potential challengers among excluded groups.

As such, in times of domestic turmoil, states with high levels of ethnic inequality may become more internationally aggressive to legitimize the ruler's position, demonstrate the state's strength to domestic challengers, and rally the co-ethnic groups' coherent support to weather the

storm. Diversion is an especially attractive option if there exists an international rivalry that marginalizes the home state's ethnic kin.

Political Inequality, Divergent Identities, and Baseline Condition

In the presence of ethnic (political) inequality, one or a few ethnic groups have access to most of the state power and resources while a significant proportion of other groups are excluded (Chandra and Wilkinson 2008). This structural imbalance of political access leads to a higher salience of ethnic identity, greater tensions among ethnic groups, and increased potential for social conflicts and threats to the state (Singh 2015). This baseline condition is created through a combination of both bottom-up and top-down mechanisms in both the dominant and excluded groups.

On the one hand, for members of the *ethnic groups being excluded (EGEs)***,** political inequality increases salience of ethnic attachment over national identity and generates ethnic-based grievances. Particularly, unequal access to state resources makes EGEs' members perceive life opportunities as mainly shaped by their ethnic identities (Singh 2015), causing disadvantaged ethnics to grow an attachment to their group identities and reduce their attachment to the national identity (Singh and vom Hau 2016; Cederman et al. 2013; Wimmer 2017). This pattern has been documented both in Africa and across the globe: individuals are found to identify more with the nation if their ethnic group is in power, while they are more likely to identify with their ethnic group if they are not represented in the executive branch (Green 2018; Wimmer 2017). The combined ethnic attachment and frustrations of EGEs form underlying conditions that can lead to social conflicts threatening the state's rule (Singh and vom Hau 2016; Wimmer 2017; Cederman et al. 2013).

On the other hand, favorable access to the political system can make members of *ethnic group(s) in power (EGIPs)* develop ethnic nationalism (Wimmer 2017). As a more exclusive form of nationalism, ethnic nationalism entails stronger pride and attachment to the nation and state yet legitimizes ethnic hierarchies among a country's own citizens. Put differently, ethnic nationalism justifies the marginalization of other ethnic groups in favor of one or a few groups (Tudor and Slater 2021; Mylonas and Tudor 2021).

For leaders of states who promote political inequality along ethnic cleavages, their political survival is tied to (1) the support of a narrower segment of the population (the EGIPs) and (2) the neutralization of threats from excluded ethnics. Given the logic of political survival, political elites are incentivized to form policies that appeal to their ethnic constituency even at the expense of other groups (Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003; Saideman and Ayres 2008; Carment 1993; Carment and James 1995). This reduces state elites' incentives to expand the state capacity and public services across the whole population, limiting public goods instead to their preferred ethnic group(s) (Singh and vom Hau 2014, 248; Wimmer et al. 2009; Wimmer 2002).

The opposite development of identities and perceptions among the EGIPs and EGEs becomes a breeding ground for ethnic tensions – especially when the marginalized ethnic groups are large. Posner (2004) found that group size is a key factor that allows political entrepreneurs to mobilize groups. In countries whose political structures exclude large ethnic groups, the imbalanced resource distribution, along with grievances and strong ethnic identity, will further fuel distributional conflicts over state resources along ethnic lines. These create underlying conditions that *potentially* give rise to more intense (and violent) forms of mobilization against the state (Singh and vom Hau 2016; Cederman, Gleditsch, and Buhaug 2013).

Such potential for mobilization makes the state's political elites even more aware when making policies. Because large EGEs can be perceived as latent threats to the state, leaders now must think about not only appealing to the EGIPs' supporters but also keeping the EGEs' grievances from turning into mobilization against the state.

Domestic Turmoil, Policy Options and Constraints

Domestic crises are catalytic events upsetting the state's effort to maintain such a fragile multi-ethnic power imbalance. Among the domestic problems that a government can face, domestic strife (or mass unrest) is perhaps the most direct and salient issue.[2] Physical threats such as mass unrest can potentially emerge from two sources: opposition from segments within the state's own ethnic base (EGIPs) and peripheral opposition representing the EGEs' grievances against the state.

Even though the two sources of mass unrest differ in nature, I argue that they threaten the state in similar ways. First, whether the unrest comes from the state's co-ethnic members or ethnic others, such security crises pose direct challenges to the state elites' rule. Second, regardless of the source, domestic unrest also creates indirect threats against the state by serving as inspiration for other potential opposition groups who have yet to mobilize (including those who represent EGEs).

Dealing with this dual threat is immensely difficult. To achieve political survival, state elites must balance between appeasing the EGIPs and keeping the latent threats from the EGEs at bay. This means that when facing domestic unrest, state leaders must respond in a way that maintains an unequal political structure that benefits group(s) in power, while paying attention to how its response is being watched by the marginalized ethnic groups who have yet to mobilize.

Facing such threats, states can respond in three main ways: accommodation, repression, and diversion – with one policy substituting or supplementing the others. As rational actors, state leaders will choose the optimal response – either a single or combination of policies – depending

[2] Evidence of economic problems' impact on diversionary conflict are mixed (Mitchell and Prins 2004; Pickering and Kisangani 2010, 2005; Wiegand 2018). As such, rather than focusing on economic issues that may or may not lead to mobilized oppositions, I direct my attention to actual mobilizations that pose direct threats to the government.
I also discuss the role of economic problems in the discussion section and explored the effect of inflation as a proxy for economic performance in **appendix E**.

on the constraints and opportunities available (Oakes 2012, 2006; Morgan and Palmer 2000; Davies 2016, 2002).

First, the state can accommodate (or co-opt) demands from the opposition (whether they represent marginalized ethnicities or not). While this is possible, this may not be a path preferred by the state (if at all), especially if it excludes large ethnic groups. This is because co-optation of an opposition group in this situation may not only (1) be costly but also (2) invite future challenges from the EGEs. If the demands come from opposition segments within the EGIPs, co-optation is difficult even if state leaders want to. When a state marginalizes a large portion of the population, state authorities tend to focus their resources on providing public goods for their own ethnic supporters, which in turn limits the state's both extractive and administrative abilities in other communities (Singh and vom Hau 2014; Wimmer 2002). This ultimately limits state capacity to mobilize resources and implement reforms that are necessary to address mass unrest (Oakes 2006, 2012).

Co-optation is even harder if the demands come from marginalized ethnic groups. In addition to the limited capacity, the state may also have little willingness to accommodate the ethnic others as co-optation can motivate other groups to mobilize and make further demands to the state in the future (Walter 2006). Additionally, co-opting the marginalized may threaten the benefits of both state elites and their co-ethnics. Letting large groups join the table means the EGIPs may lose not only a large share of spoils but potentially their political power altogether – as there is no guarantee that, once allowed access to state resources, such sizable EGEs will not use the newfound powers to retaliate or marginalize the group(s) currently in charge (Kaufmann and Haklai 2008; Peleg 2007). Indeed, dominant groups tend to view the opening of the political system for other actors as a "collective suicide" (Peleg 2007, 67–68), giving state leaders even lower willingness to accommodate marginalized ethnic groups.

Because of this, the state can and does turn to the second option – repression – to deal with domestic unrest (Davenport et al. 2019; Davies 2016). However, repression alone may not be enough in the face of domestic crises. If the unrest comes from segments within the EGIPs, then repression would be politically costly for states with high levels of ethnic exclusion. This is because repressing co-ethnic dissidents can decrease the cohesion and support of the very ethnic base that state leaders desperately need to survive.

For the EGEs, the state can opt to selectively repress specific ethnic groups – either as a domestic diversion to rally co-ethnics[3] or as a direct response to unrest organized by the excluded group (Martinez Machain and Rosenberg 2018; Tir and Jasinski 2008). However, this may only work when such excluded groups are minorities. The larger the excluded group(s) are, the more costly repression can become. This is because repression requires resources – especially if used at a large scale for a sustained period (Martinez Machain and Rosenberg 2018; Oakes 2006). Furthermore, even if the state has enough resources to commit to effective repression, coercive

[3] This is also known as domestic diversion (Martinez-Machain and Rosenberg 2018; Tir and Jasinski 2008)

policies are probably already used extensively by an ethnically exclusive state to maintain its system – even in the absence of crises (Rørbæk and Knudsen 2017). Thus, during times of mass unrest, additional repression may not help significantly with addressing the threats at hand.

With both co-optation and repression becoming inadequate, diversionary conflict becomes a more attractive option for ethnically exclusive states – whose elites depend on their ethnic selectorate's support. First, diversionary conflict against an external target allows leaders to frame political issues in ethno-nationalist terms, directing attention toward a scapegoat and increasing the cohesive support of the state's own ethnic base – without the cost of repressing or co-opting their demands (Gagnon 1994). The already stronger sense of ethno-nationalism among the EGIPs' members in ethnically exclusive states lowers the costs and increase the gains of aggressive foreign policy actions (Wimmer 2017; Green 2018; Saideman and Ayres 2008; Mylonas and Tudor 2021). Indeed, evidence shows that states' engagement in external conflicts increase in-group members' ethno-nationalist sentiments, social cohesion, and support for their leaders (Sambanis et al. 2015; Haynes 2016; Theiler 2018).

Second, diversionary use of force can also serve as a show of strength to the marginalized ethnic groups, deterring them from challenging the state. Previous research suggests that external conflicts can increase leaders' domestic support by demonstrating their competence. The assumption is that the public tends to view active leaders in the international arena as more capable and confident (Smith 1998; Fordham 1998; Ostrom and Job 1986; Haynes 2017). Following this logic, it is possible that leaders expect a show of force against an external foe will deter potential challengers (particularly out-groups) against the government.

Given these reasons, I expect the probability of external diversion will increase when leaders of ethnically exclusive states face domestic turmoil. Evidence suggests this pattern: states tend to employ external conflict as a diversionary tactic when facing severe domestic problems, either as a supplement or substitution to repression and co-optation (Davies 2002; Oakes 2012). Diversion is a particularly attractive option for states whose capacity is too low to provide public goods and services in times of crises (Lee et al. 2022).

The theory's mechanism is demonstrated in the case of Morocco in the early 1960s. Being a new ruler, King Hassan II faced demands from various Arab-led opposition forces – mainly the leftist National Union of Popular Forces (UNFP) and the nationalist Istiqlal Party. Despite Hassan's attempt to accommodate various parties through the 1962 constitution, such cooptation was not enough as it preserved too much power for the monarchy. Soon after the constitution, the Istiqlal and UNFP formed the *Kutla Wataniyya* (National Front) to criticize the King's newly adopted constitution, boycotted local elections, and demanded further policy concessions (Damis 1972; Lan 2025). Notably, despite the two parties' different ideologies, their joint *Kutla* mentioned Morocco's need to liberate territories "under foreign dominance" (Damis 1972, 28). Meanwhile, threats from the excluded indigenous Berbers (which constituted 40% of the Moroccan population)

were in the background: just a few years before (1958 – 1959), Berber tribes in the Rif region revolted against the government, leading to thousands of casualties.

Given the looming threats from the excluded ethnic groups, along with opposition from a fragmented co-ethnic base, the incentive for a diversionary conflict is nontrivial. Comprehensive cooptation was not possible as it would damage monarchical power. In addition, since Hassan's position is dependent on ethnic Arabs' coherent support, heavy repression of Arab-led groups was too costly (especially given Hassan's short tenure as king).

Given the costs of both cooptation and repression, the escalation of border disputes with Algeria to reclaim Morocco's rightful territories became an attractive option for Hassan after years of political dissent from multiple groups (Lan 2025; S. G. Miller 2013). Despite his previous removal of Istiqlal's leader, al-Fassi, from the government in 1961 and suppression of the nationalists' demands for government-sanctioned territorial conquests to establish a "Greater Morocco", Hassan became committed to this militarization by 1963.

> **Hypothesis 1**: *States with larger excluded ethnic groups are more likely to initiate international conflict when they face domestic turmoil.*

Of course, this does not mean that diversionary conflict is actually effective in mitigating the intense problems facing state leaders. Although there is evidence that diversion can boost support for leaders among in-group members – shown by quantitative analyses as well as individual cases of dramatic surges in public support for Putin after Russia's annexation of Crimea in 2014 or for Hassan II during the Sand War in 1963 (Kisangani and Pickering 2009; Theiler 2018; Lan 2025) – this study focuses on the leader's *perception* that external use of force may help increase co-ethnics' support while demonstrating strength to domestic challengers.

Rivalry, Transnational Kinship and Diversionary Opportunity

While the presence of political inequality and domestic turmoil raises the overall probability of conflict, I also suspect that the probability of conflict is higher for specific types of targets. In other words, struggling leaders are much more likely to start diversionary fights when there exists the opportunity to do so. This is because leaders need a good reason to start a costly international conflict, and randomly targeting any type of states can make domestic audiences punish the leader even more. To distract their in-group audiences from domestic issues and rally for their support, leaders need a target that is both recognizable and justifiable.

International rivals stand out as the ideal type of target for such a diversionary goal (Mitchell and Prins 2004; Mitchell and Thyne 2010; Lee et al. 2022). First, ongoing rivalry has been shown as an ideal type of conflict opportunity (Lee et al. 2022). Generally, an international rivalry entails tensions about salient issues between two or more states (Colaresi et al. 2008; Diehl and Goertz 2001). A history of hostilities and contentious issues provides opportunities which embattled leaders can capitalize on and escalate to militarized disputes. Indeed, rivals tend to fight frequently and repeatedly (Thompson et al. 2022).

Second, an international rival can be easily recognizable and framed as the enemy. Rivals are defined as states that view each other as enemies and competitors (based on their diplomatic history), making rivalries recognizable and easily known to the public (Thompson et al. 2022; Thompson and Dreyer 2011). A rival's ability to be portrayed as a grave threat to the in-group makes it an ideal target, given that the goal is to invoke a sense of in-group cohesion and ethno-nationalism as well as direct the audiences' attention to the common foe. In other words, I argue that the existence of an ongoing rivalry can change the conflict calculus of ethnically unequal states, making conflicts more likely to occur against the rival targets. In the case of Morocco, the Sand War was also framed as an attempt to not only reclaim Morocco's rightful territory but also defend against the king's ideological rivals, the socialist Algeria and Egypt, which further increased unity and support among Moroccan citizens and elites (including the opposition Istiqlal Party).

> **Hypothesis 2:** *States with larger marginalized ethnic groups and facing domestic turmoil are more likely to initiate conflict against international rivals (compared to non-rival targets)*.

But which type of rivals would offer the best opportunity for a state where ethnic political inequality is widespread? Given the goal is to rally in-group members' support, leaders of an ethnically exclusive state will be most likely to target rivals that have ethnic ties with the home state – particularly those rivals that marginalize the home state's EGIPs. Such rival targets offer home state leaders not only the opportunity for diversion but also the highest ability to rally their co-ethnic group(s), which is convenient for the home state's leadership given their reliance on their co-ethnic members' support especially in times of turmoil.

Particularly, the existence of ethnic kin group(s) in another state allows home state leaders to justify the conflict as an effort to reclaim their homeland and rescue their kin who are ruled by ethnic others in a rival enemy (Saideman and Ayres 2008; Goemans and Schultz 2017; Shelef 2016). If the home state's EGIPs are excluded from political power in the target state (especially a rival), then politicizing such issues can provoke stronger feelings of co-ethnics' in-group attachment and out-group bias. As such, embattled leaders in the home state have even more incentives to initiate conflict against such a target to improve their legitimacy and political support (Carment and James 1995; Goemans and Schultz 2017). A recent example of this was Russia's claim of mistreatment of ethnic Russians inside Ukrainian borders (Theiler 2018). Despite its debatable accuracy, such a claim can justify a state's acts of aggression and strengthen the leader's legitimacy. Similarly, Armenia's conflict with Azerbaijan over the treatment of ethnic Armenians in the Nagorno-Karabakh region has also allowed Armenian leaders to mobilize and/or divert their domestic audiences on various occasions (Saideman and Ayres 2008).

Hypothesis 3: *States that have high ethnic exclusion and face domestic turmoil will be most likely to start conflict against rivals who marginalize the home state's EGIPs.*

Research Design & Data[4]

To evaluate the proposed hypotheses, this study employs a series of logistic regression analyses to examine whether a state with high ethnic political inequality and is facing domestic turmoil is more likely to start militarized interstate disputes (MIDs) with other states.[5] The sample of the analyses includes politically relevant dyads (PRDs) across the globe from 1946 to 2014.[6] This means that I include pairs of states that either (1) have at least one major power or (2) are contiguous through land or water. Due to the already rare nature of MIDs as well as the very high number of potential (directed) dyads in the time frame (over one million observations), this restriction on PRDs is meant to include only dyads that have opportunities for conflict.

The use of directed dyad-years takes into account which state in a pair is initiating the conflict, which fits with this study's analytical purpose. In addition, the structure of the directed dyad-year data makes it easier to include control variables that are inherently dyadic and are abundantly available for dyad data. The list of initiating states (state A) and target states (state B) for this research is drawn from the Dyadic Militarized Interstate Dispute (MID) Data 4.02 in the Correlates of War project (Maoz et al. 2018).

Dependent Variable

The main dependent variable is a dichotomous indicator of a militarized interstate dispute (MID) in a dyad. A MID event is defined as a conflict in which a state's threat, display, use of military force, or war by an internationally recognized state is explicitly directed towards another state's government, official representatives, official forces, property, or territory (Maoz et al. 2018). The outcome variable shows a value of 1 if a state initiates a MID against the target state in the directed dyad in a given year. The variable shows a value of 0 otherwise. The data is drawn from the Dyadic Militarized Interstate Disputes (MID) database (Maoz et al. 2018).

Independent Variables

Ethnic Political Inequality: Data measuring the level of political inequality among ethnic groups is drawn from the Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) dataset (Vogt et al. 2015). The dataset includes only politically relevant ethnic groups, defined as groups that either (1) have at least one significant political organization claiming to represent the interests of such groups in national politics or (2) are systematically marginalized in politics. Given its focus on politically relevant groups, the EPR data includes ethnic groups that can potentially be mobilized, which fits with this study's theoretical mechanism.

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[4] Descriptive statistics for dependent and independent variables are included in **Appendix A**.

[5] I conducted some robustness checks using the random effects (REs) estimator and rare events maximum likelihood estimators (penalized MLE). There are differences in results, but the conclusion drawn from these checks are largely the same. Results of the REs and rare events models are shown in **Appendices B and C**, respectively.

[6] The data for independent variable (ethnic inequality) is available from 1946, while the MID dataset ends in 2014 – hence the 1946-2014 time period.

The variable used in this study is the *degree of ethnic exclusion from executive government*. Particularly, it is the population share of excluded ethnic groups (those that do not monopolize, dominate, or enter executive ruling coalitions as senior or junior partners) relative to the state's entire population. This variable is taken from GROWUP, an EPR data interface (Vogt et al. 2015). The ethnic exclusion variable is lagged for one year to ensure that the political inequality among ethnic groups precedes the current year's conflict.

Mass Unrest: This study uses a common measure of domestic turmoil taken from the Cross-National Time-Series data (Banks and Wilson 2022). The initial count variable captures the total number of riots, strikes, and mass public demonstrations for each country in each year. These events are signs that a portion of a country's population is frustrated with the government's performance and has decided to mobilize, making it appropriate to test my argument. In addition, the variable is indicates the government's poor performance in various aspects, not just the economy. Thus, it is an overall good measure for this study. I *lag* the unrest variable one year to ensure that it is prior to conflict.

Ongoing Rivalry: Following previous research on international rivalries, this study draws data on international rivalries from Thompson, Sakuwa, and Suhas (2022), which was gathered and transformed into a data file by Miller (2022). The dataset defines a rivalry as "antagonistic relationships between comparable competitors who *regard each other as threatening enemies*" (Thompson et al. 2022, 26). This definition focuses on the perception of states themselves, directly extracting decision makers' views (from policy documents, diplomatic communiqués, etc.) on which opponents are viewed as "threatening enemies." In other words, list of rivalries is coded by a team of experts (Thompson et al. 2022) who *identify a pair of rival states only when relevant historical documents show that decision makers on both sides view each other as a threat, and that leaders also take the existence of the opponent into account when making major foreign policies*. This perceptual aspect also means that ongoing rivals are known and visible to the public in the home state – making them prime targets for diversion.

The variable *Ongoing Rivalry* in this dataset takes the value of 1 to indicate a pair of states to be rivals – meaning that decision makers in both states in the dyad perceive each other as "threatening enemies" (as indicated in their policy documents, reports, and other historical archives, etc.). The variable has a value of 0 for cases showing otherwise.

Ethnic Ties in Rival Target: To test the third hypothesis, a variable capturing whether a home state (state A) has ethnic kin within a rival target. Drawing on the Transborder Ethnic Kin dataset from the EPR database (Vogt et al. 2015), I created an ordered categorical variable combining information about rivalry and transborder ethnic kinships. This three-level variable indicates whether the potential target is not a rival of the home state (0), a rival but does not have or marginalize the home state's EGIP (1), and a rival where the EGIP(s) in the home state are marginalized (2). This setup enables me to compare the effects of ethnic kinship in rivals to that of rivals without the home state's EGIP(s).

Control Variables

Ethnic Fractionalization: Ethnic diversity has been shown to be a baseline condition that influences the risk of international conflict (Haynes 2016). I thus include a control measure of ethnic fragmentation from the Composition of Religious and Ethnic Groups (CREG) project (Nardulli et al. 2012). The method of calculation for the measure is the commonly used Herfindahl-Hirschman concentration index introduced by Alesina et al. (2003).

Relative Capabilities: This study accounts for the power of both states in a dyad by employing an indicator of relative power – *state A's (challenger) share of the dyad's total CINC score*. The CINC score is taken from the Correlates of War's (COW) National Material Capabilities dataset. It is an index – ranging from 0 to 1 – capturing a country's military capabilities based on its total population, urban population, iron and steel production, energy consumption, military expenditure, and number of military personnel (Singer et al. 1972). The more powerful state A is relative to state B (potential target), the more likely A is to start a MID.

Foreign Policy Similarity: To account for the tendency for two countries with different foreign policy interests to fight, this study follows past IR studies and includes a measure of similarity between two countries' alliance portfolio (Sweeney and Keshk 2005). I use the s-score calculated based on alliances portfolio by the *peacesciencer* package in R (Miller 2022).

Trade Dependence: To account for the level of interdependence between the two sides of the dyad, I include a measure of the total trade volume between the two states (side A and B) in a dyad. The data for this measurement is taken from (Barbieri and Keshk 2016; Barbieri et al. 2009). More interdependent pairs of countries are expected to fight less.

Distance: The study also includes a measurement of the minimum distance between the two states in a dyad (in kilometers). The original data for this measure is calculated by cshapes 2.0 (Schvitz et al. 2022) and extracted through the *peacesciencer* package (Miller 2022). This inclusion is aimed at accounting for the loss of strength gradient that can affect the likelihood of conflict between two countries. The further away the two states are, the less likely they are expected to fight.

Polity2 Scores:[7] I include polity scores for both state A and B to account for two things. First, the inclusion of state A's polity score controls for the possibility that more democratic regimes are more inclusive of ethnic groups. Second, state A and B's polity scores also account for the democratic peace – two democracies are generally less likely to fight each other. Additionally, including both polity scores (instead of the common Joint Democracy dummy variable) has the bonus effect of preserving regime-related information and variation, making the estimation process easier. These scores are drawn from the Polity5 project (Marshall and Gurr 2020). The score ranges from -10 (most autocratic) to 10 (most democratic).

[7] I estimated the models with Joint Democracy replacing Polity2 scores, results remain mostly similar (appendix D).

Temporal dependence: In this study, time dependence is controlled for by a measure of peace years in a dyad – in other words, the number of years since a pair of states last fought a militarized dispute – along with the squared and cubic terms of peace years. This aims to control for the fact that two countries that have longer peace periods are less likely to fight.

Analysis

The results for hypotheses 1 and 2 are shown in Table 1. Particularly, I estimate two models with the inclusion of a two-way interaction term between ethnic inequality and domestic unrest (model 1) and a three-way interaction term between ethnic inequality, domestic unrest, and ongoing rivalry (model 2). Both models suggest that the proxy measure for ethnic political inequality – ethnic exclusion (the share of excluded ethnic population from executive government) – has statistically significant (main effect) coefficients at 0.01 level. This suggests that ethnic political inequality is positively associated with a higher probability of international conflict initiated by a state.

Most control variables behave as expected. Overall, a state (state A) is more likely to initiate a MID against the target if state A is less democratic and has higher military capabilities than state B. Conflict is also more likely to occur if states have lower foreign policy similarity, smaller distance, and shorter periods of peace. Interestingly, the coefficient for ethnic fractionalization is not statistically different from zero, suggesting that ethnic diversity does not always lead to aggression – the key is perhaps whether and how such diversity is politicized by the unequal power configurations.

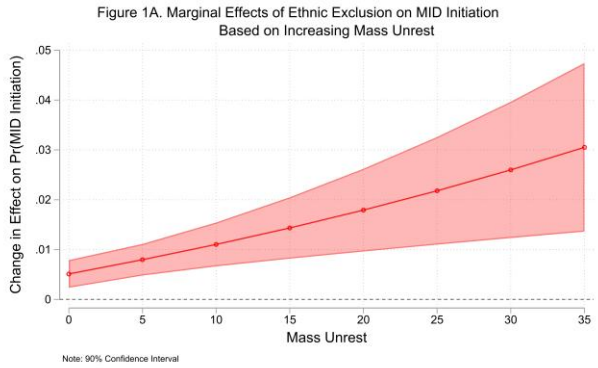
Table 1. Logistic Regression of MID Initiation

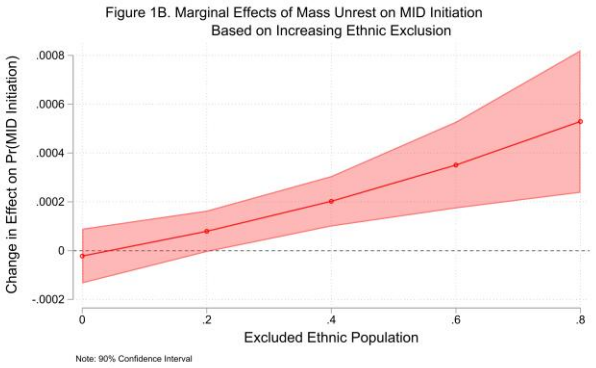
	Model 1 Inequality-Mass Unrest	Model 2 Three-way Interaction
DV: MID Initiation		
Ethnic Exclusion	0.460***	0.524***
	(0.152)	(0.198)
Mass Unrest	-0.002	-0.001
	(0.007)	(0.008)
Ongoing Rivalry	___	1.397***
		(0.140)
Ethnic Exclusion * Mass Unrest	0.046**	0.039**
	(0.018)	(0.019)
Ongoing Rivalry * Ethnic Exclusion	___	-0.675**
		(0.301)
Ongoing Rivalry * Mass Unrest	___	-0.009
		(0.016)
Ongoing Rivalry * Ethnic Exclusion * Mass Unrest	___	0.018
		(0.044)
Ethnic Fractionalization	-0.069	-0.015

	(0.170)	(0.160)
Side A's Relative Capabilities	0.417***	0.478***
	(0.106)	(0.113)
Dyad's Trade Volume	0.000***	0.000*
	(0.000)	(0.000)
FP Similarity	-1.494***	-1.396***
	(0.237)	(0.184)
Polity Score A	-0.028***	-0.022***
	(0.006)	(0.006)
Polity Score B	0.004	0.011*
	(0.006)	(0.006)
Distance	-0.000***	-0.000***
	(0.000)	(0.000)
Peace Years	-0.351***	-0.284***
	(0.019)	(0.018)
Peace Years^2	0.012***	0.010***
	(0.001)	(0.001)
Peace Years^3	-0.000***	-0.000***
	(0.000)	(0.000)
Constant	-1.098***	-1.823***
	(0.218)	(0.202)
N	112,241	112,241
N Clusters (Directed Dyads)	2846	2846
Pseudo R^2	0.199	0.217
Log-likelihood	-5862.076	-5709.357
χ^2	1624.366	2639.584

Clustered (dyad-level) standard errors in parentheses
*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

The interaction effect between ethnic political inequality and mass unrest is demonstrated in Figure 1. As can be seen from Figures 1A and 1B, the interaction effect is positive. Figure 1A shows that when there is no mass unrest, the AME of higher ethnic exclusion on MID initiation is around 0.006. When domestic unrest in state A becomes more severe, the probability of MID initiation increases to over 0.03 – a five-fold increase in conflict risk. The result supports hypothesis 1 that domestic turmoil poses imminent threats to ruling ethnic group(s), making ethnically unequal states grow even more aggressive as they find diversionary international conflict an attractive option.





The moderating effect of ethnic political inequality (as a moderating factor) is demonstrated in Figure 1B. Similar to previous studies, mass unrest is found to have a positive effect on MID initiation. However, this effect is only statistically significant once a state excludes more than 20% of its politically relevant ethnic population. In such cases, each additional mass unrest event (riot, demonstration, or strike) is associated with a 0.0001 increase in the probability of MID initiation by the home state (state A). When the population share of all excluded ethnic groups is 0.8, each additional mass unrest event results in almost a 0.0005 increase in MID initiation probability – again, a five-fold increase.

Three-Way Interaction: Ethnic Inequality, Domestic Turmoil, and Ongoing Rivalry

To assess hypothesis 2, I include a three-way interaction between ethnic exclusion, mass unrest, and ongoing rivalry in model 2. While the three-way interaction effects can be explored by a model with a 2-way interaction term (between two continuous variables) for 2 subsamples (one for non-rival dyads and the other for rival dyads), I opt to estimate a model with a three-way interaction term due to two main reasons. First, I am interested in not only whether MID probability against a rival is higher than that against non-rival targets but also *by how much*. In other words, I want to estimate the magnitude of the effect of a state's ongoing rivalry on its MID initiation probability – conditional to the levels of ethnic exclusion and mass unrest. A three-way interaction enables me to calculate the difference in MEs between when a rivalry is present (the treatment) and non-rivals (the baseline condition), while a multi-sample approach cannot.

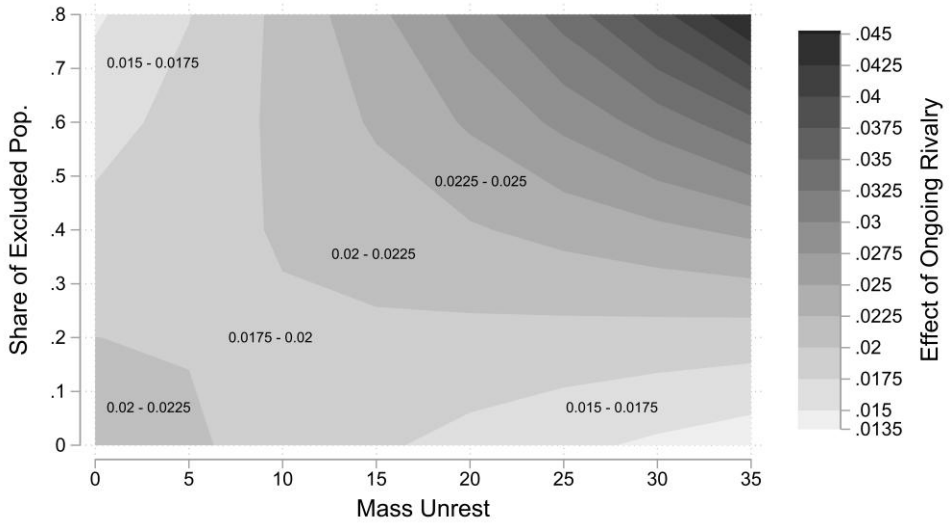
Second, because the two subsamples will be vastly different in terms of size, diversity, etc., the findings for the two sub-samples may be incomparable. There are only over 6,200 dyad-years (about 4% of the sample) that have an ongoing rivalry.[8] Given such clear discrepancies, informal comparisons between two subsamples can produce unreliable generalizations and insights.

Figure 2 demonstrates the AME of ongoing rivalry on MID probability. Due to the three-way interaction's complexity, I use a contour plot to visualize the difference in conflict probability between rival and non-rival targets. In each contour plot, the two axes represent two continuous variables, and each segment of the plot surface corresponds to a different interval of the average

[8] See **Appendix A**

marginal effects of ongoing rivalry on MID probability. Darker segments of the plot reflect higher probabilities of MID initiation against the rival (as opposed to non-rival targets).

Figure 2. Marginal Effects of Rivalry on MID Initiation
Based on Ethnic Exclusion & Mass Unrest



If we fix the level of ethnic exclusion to lower values (between 0 and 0.2 of the population), it can be seen that the probability of ongoing rivals being targeted (compared to non-rivals) decreases from 0.0225 to under 0.015 as mass unrest increases to 35 incidents. Even though rivals are always the preferred target over non-rivals (given marginal effects are always positive), the result suggests that as a state's ethnic exclusion is low or non-existent, the state's tendency to target rivals (compared to non-rivals) declines as mass unrest increases.

Similarly, when a state experiences the lowest level of mass unrest (0 – 5 events), the probability of MID initiation against a rival target (as opposed to a non-rival) decreases from over 0.02 (when ethnic exclusion is 0) to under 0.015 (as ethnic exclusion in state A increases to 0.8). Nevertheless, as the level of mass unrest increases, interesting patterns emerge. For example, if a state's excluded ethnic groups make up 0.3 of its population, that state's MID probability against an international rival is between 0.0175 and 0.02 when there are fewer than 10 incidents. But if that state faces over 10 events of mass unrest that year, the probability of MID against a rival increases to 0.02-0.0225. Similarly, as the level of ethnic exclusion and mass unrest increases, the AME of ongoing rivalry also increases. At the most severe level of ethnic inequality (0.8) and domestic turmoil (35), the AME of ongoing rivalry on MID initiation increases to 0.045. This number doubles the MID probability when a state has zero ethnic exclusion and no mass unrest (0.02 to 0.0225) and more than triples MID initiation probability when a state only must deal with either severe ethnic inequality or mass unrest (0.0135 – 0.015).

Together, these results suggest that as a state faces either problem (ethnic exclusion or domestic turmoil), its preference for rival targets decreases. However, as both problems become

increasingly severe, states are more likely to not only initiate international conflicts but also target ongoing rivals. The plot also shows that an ethnic exclusion level of 0.25+ and a domestic turmoil level of 10+ incidents appear to be clear breaks marking where states turn more belligerent, especially against their ongoing rival(s). These findings provide support for hypothesis 2.

Taking Into Account Ethnic Kinship in Rivals

To test hypothesis 3, I incorporate information about transborder ethnic kinship into the rivalry via a three-way interaction term between ethnic exclusion, mass unrest, and the ethnic-ties-in-rival variable. In other words, instead of a binary variable for rivalry, I include an ordinal categorical variable in the three-way interaction. This variable takes a value of 0 when the potential target is not a rival of the home state, a value of 1 when the target is a rival but does not marginalize the home state's EGIP, and a value of 2 when a target is a rival who also marginalizes the home state's EGIP(s).

Table 2 shows the model that includes a three-way interaction for hypothesis 3. Given that the rival-ethnic kin variable has 3 categories, I estimated the same model but in two different ways: one where the baseline category comprises non-rival targets (0) and the other where the baseline consists of other rivals who do *not* marginalize state A's EGIPs (1). This setup allows me to conduct a dual comparison between the probability of MID against rivals who marginalize state A's EGIPs and that of categories 0 (non-rivals) and 1 (other rivals). Through these comparisons, I can examine not only the effect of each rival type (based on their ethnic ties with the home state) compared to the non-rivals but also the effect of ethnic ties within the subsample of rivals.

Table 2. Logistic Regression with Three-Way Interaction

	Model 3A Baseline: Non-Rival	Model 3B Baseline: Other Rivals
DV: MID Initiation		
Ethnic Exclusion	0.512***	-0.170
	(0.197)	(0.259)
Mass Unrest	-0.001	-0.009
	(0.008)	(0.015)
Ethnic Exclusion * Mass Unrest	0.039**	0.052
	(0.019)	(0.043)
Non-Rival	___	-1.340***
		(0.145)
Rival (Other)	1.340***	___
	(0.145)	
Rival (EGIPA Marginalized)	1.633***	0.293
	(0.221)	(0.216)
Non-Rival * Exclusion	___	0.683**
		(0.316)
Non-Rival * Unrest	___	0.008

		(0.017)
Rival (Other) * Exclusion	-0.683**	___
	(0.316)	
Rival (Other) * Unrest	-0.008	___
	(0.017)	
Rival (EGIPA Marginalized) * Exclusion	-0.903*	-0.221
	(0.541)	(0.560)
Rival (EGIPA Marginalized) * Unrest	-0.066**	-0.058*
	(0.027)	(0.030)
Non-Rival * Exclusion * Unrest	___	-0.012
		(0.047)
Rival (Other) * Exclusion * Unrest	0.012	___
	(0.047)	
Rival (EGIPA Marginalized) * Exclusion * Unrest	0.435***	0.423***
	(0.095)	(0.102)
Eth. Frac.	-0.007	-0.007
	(0.162)	(0.162)
Side A's Relative Capabilities	0.483***	0.483***
	(0.110)	(0.110)
Dyad's Trade Volume	0.000*	0.000*
	(0.000)	(0.000)
FP Similarity	-1.440***	-1.440***
	(0.180)	(0.180)
Polity Score A	-0.023***	-0.023***
	(0.006)	(0.006)
Polity Score B	0.010*	0.010*
	(0.006)	(0.006)
Minimum Distance	-0.000***	-0.000***
	(0.000)	(0.000)
Peace Years	-0.283***	-0.283***
	(0.018)	(0.018)
Peace Years^2	0.010***	0.010***
	(0.001)	(0.001)
Peace Years^3	-0.000***	-0.000***
	(0.000)	(0.000)
Constant	-1.794***	-0.454**
	(0.198)	(0.205)
N	112241	112241
N Clusters (Directed Dyads)	2846	2846
Pseudo R^2	0.221	0.221
Log-likelihood	-5702.547	-5702.547
χ^2	2928.013	2928.013

Clustered (dyad-level) standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

The visualization in Figures 3A and 3B confirms that rivals (in general) are the preferred targets compared to non-rivals. Figure 3A shows a similar pattern to figure 2, suggesting that ethnically exclusive states (state A) that are also experiencing mass unrest prefer to initiate MIDs against rivals, even those who do not marginalize (or do not have ties with) the home state's EGIPs. However, Figure 3B reveals a much stronger tendency of states to specifically target rivals who marginalize the home state's kin, with the probability of MID initiation increasing up to 0.96 (compared to 0.035 for rivals who do not exclude state A's EGIPs!).

Figure 3A. Marginal Effects of Other Rivals (Who Do Not Marginalize State A's EGIPs) Compared to Non-Rival Targets

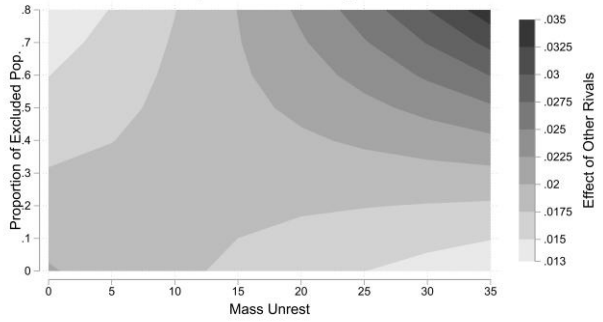


Figure 3B. Marginal Effects of Rivals Who Marginalize State A's EGIPs Compared to Non-Rival Targets

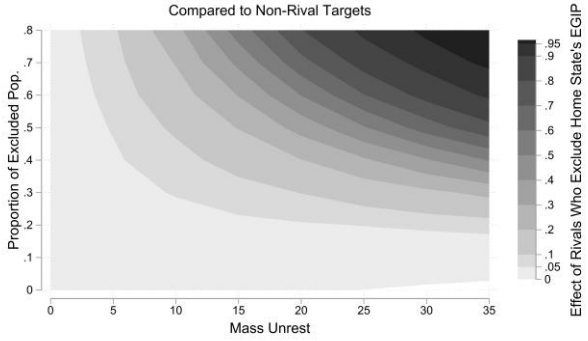


Figure 3C. Marginal Effects of Rivals Who Marginalize State A's EGIPs Compared to Other Rivals (State A's EGIPs Not Marginalized)

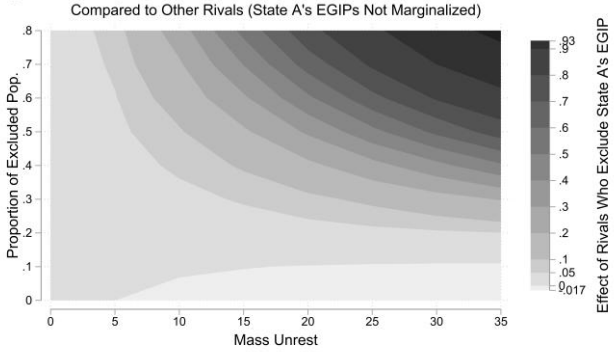


Figure 3C shows a strong tendency of ethnically exclusive home states to respond to domestic unrest by attacking rivals who marginalize the home state's EGIPs. Specifically, as both ethnic political exclusion and mass unrest increase, states are much more likely to initiate MIDs against rivals where the home states' EGIPs are powerless (compared to other rivals who do not marginalize the home states' EGIPs). This evidence supports hypothesis 3 that as a state becomes more ethnically exclusive, its leaders become more dependent on co-ethnic members. When facing domestic turmoil, such elites are most likely to initiate diversionary conflict against targets that can ensure the highest rally effect for co-ethnic audiences.

Discussion & Conclusion

This study addresses an important and interesting gap in the literature of ethnicity and international conflict by examining how *disproportionate* ethnic political power shapes leaders' decisions to use diversionary force. I argue that countries with high levels of ethnic political

inequality (measured by the size of excluded ethnic population) generate two parallel dynamics that heighten instability. On the one hand, disproportionate exclusion (i.e., large ethnic groups being denied access to executive power and resources) makes state elites reliant on the support of a narrow co-ethnic coalition and encourages ethnic nationalism among members of the ethnic groups in power (EGIPs). On the other hand, members of the excluded ethnic groups (EGEs) develop grievances and potential for anti-state mobilization (especially if they are large in size). Together, these pressures shape leaders' calculus for political survival: to maintain power, leaders must appease their co-ethnics and maintain their unity (sometimes by nationalist policies if necessary), while keeping latent threats from EGEs at bay.

Domestic turmoil, particularly mass unrest, can upset this delicate balance. But leaders of ethnically exclusive states have limited options to respond to such crises. States that exclude large ethnic groups may not have enough resources, capacity, and willingness to accommodate citizens (whether the opposition represents factions of the EGIPs or EGEs). Large-scale and prolonged repression is either politically costly or logistically difficult. These constraints make diversionary conflict a more attractive option for leaders to unite the EGIPs, rally co-ethnic support, and signals strength to potential challengers.

The utility of diversion is even higher if there exist targets that (1) offer leaders the opportunity and justification for conflict and (2) create a rallying effect among the co-ethnic base. International rival states provide opportunities for escalations of ongoing hostilities into militarized conflicts, while rivals who also marginalize the home state's ethnic kin allow for powerful nationalist propaganda. Such targets enable home state leaders to frame conflicts as efforts to rescue ethnic kin or reclaim the homeland, thereby rallying the maximum support from co-ethnic members.

Statistical evidence aligns with these theoretical expectations. Data analyses support the first hypothesis that states with higher ethnic inequality are more likely to initiate MIDs – particularly against rival states – during periods of mass unrest. While rivals in general are preferred targets, those who marginalize the home state's ethnic kin are much more likely to be chosen.

These findings contribute to research on ethnic politics and diversionary conflict. First, they identify ethnic political inequality as an important domestic condition shaping a state's diversionary incentives. While previous research shows that ethnic diversity and ethnic mobilization increase states' propensity for international conflict (Haynes 2016; Lake and Rothchild 1998; Trumbore 2003), the mechanisms linking ethnic cleavages to external diversion have remained underexplored. By turning the attention to ethnic political inequality, this study shows how ethnic stratification can foster nationalist sentiments (among groups in power) and deep-seated grievances (among excluded groups) – both of which fuel ethnic tensions and structural pressures that motivate diversionary behavior.

Second, the findings also add to the literature on nationalism and irredentism. The findings align with previous studies: the dominance of a few ethnic groups promotes nationalist foreign policies by tying a leader's political survival to a narrow selectorate with strong identity attachments (Saideman and Ayres 2008; Goemans and Schultz 2017). This study also shows that transborder ethnic groups (especially in a rival state) provide ideal opportunities for diversionary conflict, echoing the so-called "Macedonian Syndrome" where states initiate territorial claims to rescue or reunite ethnic kin (Cederman et al. 2025; Saideman and Ayres 2008). At the same time, a nationalist selectorate does not always lead to conflict. By showing that domestic crises can trigger diversionary behavior among highly ethnically exclusive states, this paper clarifies a key pathway linking political inequality to nationalism and eventually to interstate conflict.

Third, this study extends the body of research on horizontal inequality and its consequences. Prior studies have shown that horizontal inequality (HI) – especially ethnic inequality – has negative impacts such as conflict (Cederman et al. 2011; Stewart 2008), low public good provision (Baldwin and Huber 2010), and underdevelopment (Alesina et al. 2016). This study's findings point to international conflict as another potential consequence of ethnic (political) inequality.

Limitations and Extensions

Despite its interesting findings, this study is not without limitations. While this paper's specific focus allows a more in-depth examination of how ethnic inequality influences the state's propensity for *international* conflict, states also respond to internal issues through other means – the most notable of which are repression and accommodation. My argument predicts repression and accommodation to be insufficient tools to deal with severe inequality and domestic turmoil (and thus makes leaders turn to diversion). As such, future work is necessary to explore whether and how these strategies substitute for or complement diversion – and how ethnic inequality shapes the tradeoffs between such policy options. Such analyses will be both interesting and important in further strengthening (or refuting) my argument.

Additionally, this study's core argument emphasizes the *breadth of exclusion*: when large ethnic populations are excluded from political power, the size of the leader's selectorate can shrink to specific ethnic groups, rendering ethno-nationalist policies appealing strategies for political survival. An important extension concerns the *depth of exclusion*: are excluded groups "merely" powerless, or actively discriminated against?

To assess this dimension, I estimated two sets of models with similar specifications compared to the main models but replaced the size of all excluded groups with (1) the population share of powerless groups and (2) the share of actively discriminated groups (appendices G and H). The results of models with the size of discriminated groups closely mirror the main analyses. In fact, the effects of the "active discrimination" models are even larger than in the main models.

In contrast, the "powerless models" reveal interesting dynamics. The effect of political exclusion alone becomes statistically significant only under severe mass unrest. The three-way interaction models demonstrate that states excluding large (but non-discriminated) groups are more likely to start conflict against rivals – but only when both political exclusion and mass unrest reach high levels (0.3 population and 20 events, respectively). When only one pressure intensifies, the probability of conflict declines. Notably, consistent with the main findings, rivals that marginalize the home state's ethnic kin remain especially attractive targets.

These results support the main theoretical story, while suggesting interesting nuances. Active discrimination likely narrows leaders' options: *large* and *discriminated* groups have strong incentives for anti-state mobilization, especially during times of domestic instabilities, making diversion more attractive for the state. On the contrary, powerless groups may be more open to compromises and/or deterred by repression, making diversionary conflict most appealing only when both ethnic exclusion and domestic unrest become severe.

Furthermore, this study concentrates on leaders' diversionary behavior when ethnic political inequality interacts with domestic stability. Thus, other problems like economic struggles or natural disasters remain largely outside of the paper's main scope, despite potentially being important triggers for diversionary conflict (Mitchell and Prins 2004; Wiegand 2018; Lee et al. 2022). In fact, economic struggles may underlie threats such as mass unrest and low public approval (Oakes 2006).

To further explore this possibility, appendix E examines the interactive effect of ethnic political inequality and *inflation* on MID initiation. In general, results are mixed and differ considerably from the main findings. While the two-way interaction between ethnic exclusion and inflation is not statistically significant, three-way interaction models show that states are most likely to divert against rivals (especially rivals who marginalize their ethnic kin) when they have (1) high inflation and (2) *low* ethnic exclusion.

Given the substantial missingness of inflation data, these results should be interpreted with caution. Yet, they at least suggest economic problems as potential motivators of diversionary conflict, but only for less exclusive states. Research on diversion in democracies may offer an explanation: Similar to democratic states, perhaps leaders of ethnically *inclusive* states are beholden to broader domestic audiences and thus face more pressure from economic problems – given how economic downturns can impact a large number of citizens (Gelpi 1997; Kisangani and Pickering 2009; Long and Pickering 2022). The interplay between ethnic inequality, regime openness, and economic issues will be an interesting future research avenue.

Finally, despite my focus on ethnic political inequality, other aspects of HI may also cause international violence. In appendix F, I examined the effects of economic inequality on diversionary conflict using the group Gini index of the EPR's nightlight data, based on formulas proposed by Mancini et al. (2008). Results suggest that ethnic economic inequality's effect on international conflict is (mostly) similar to that of ethnic political inequality. Nevertheless, the

effect is not robust: a statistically significant effect of economic inequality is only found in three-way interaction models and *may be driven by the strong effect of rivalry*. On its own, horizontal economic inequality appears to have no independent effect on MID initiation. Despite this inconsistency, such patterns suggest that economic inequality across ethnic cleavages can lead to external diversion (just as it does with civil war), warranting further explorations into how political, economic, and social inequalities influence states' propensity for diversion.

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